

THE CARRY-OVER DIAGNOSTIC

Six kinds of "unfinished," and the five-minute test for what's actually stuck.

"IT'S ALMOST DONE."

Which is interesting — it was almost done three weeks ago too.

A story that keeps carrying over is usually telling you something. Name what's actually unfinished.

1 TECHNICAL

Genuinely more implementation work. Code or integration incomplete.

2 REQUIREMENT

The team doesn't actually know what the system should do yet.

3 DEPENDENCY

Your part is done; the rest sits with another team, API or environment.

4 TESTING

Development's done, but behaviour hasn't been proven yet.

5 SCOPE

The finish line keeps moving every time someone touches the story.

6 DECISION

Someone needs to choose, and no one has.

THE FIVE-MINUTE CARRY-OVER TEST

☐ What exactly is unfinished?

☐ Who or what are we waiting for?

☐ What is the next concrete action?

☐ Why is it unfinished — which of the six?

☐ Can the completed part be separated?

REMEMBER

The thing being carried from sprint to sprint usually isn't the story. It's an unanswered question.

Next time a story appears in its third or fourth sprint, don't move it again — open it, ask what's unfinished, ask why, ask who owns the answer.